



Custom Ceremonies With Heart & Soul

WEDDING READING IDEAS

If you want ideas for readings for your ceremony, here are a ton of them. Just like you, the couples I work with are thoughtful and care about meaning, and so the readings that they've picked over the years have led to a wonderful collection for you to browse and be inspired by.

You can choose a reading or two from this document, or perhaps you'll think of a poem, writing, song, movie or book excerpt that isn't in here. Whatever touches your heart, stirs your soul, makes you laugh, etc. Last but not least, you may simply choose not to have any readings, and that's fine too.

This is also a great activity to do as a couple - oftentimes a reading is near the beginning of a ceremony, and so you can think about "how do we want to feel when we're starting our wedding" and pick accordingly. It really helps you to begin to envision the type of experience you want to have.

I've segmented this rather large document into five sections:

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Have fun and let me know if you have questions or want help!

READINGS, QUOTES, POEMS

Poem by Tyler Kent

I choose you
Again and again
At the start and finish
Of every single day
No matter the season
No matter the year

I choose you
To struggle and succeed with
To fight and make up with
To love and grow old with

I choose you
Knowing there are still trails
We must travel
Knowing there are mountains
Left to climb

I choose you
To always be by my side

"All I Know About Love" by Neil Gaiman

This is everything I have to tell you about love: nothing.
This is everything I've learned about marriage: nothing.

Only that the world out there is complicated,
and there are beasts in the night, and delight and pain,
and the only thing that makes it okay, sometimes,
is to reach out a hand in the darkness and find another hand to squeeze,
and not to be alone.

It's not the kisses, or never just the kisses: it's what they mean.
Somebody's got your back.
Somebody knows your worst self and somehow doesn't want to rescue you
or send for the army to rescue them.

It's not two broken halves becoming one.
It's the light from a distant lighthouse bringing you both safely home
because home is wherever you are both together.

So this is everything I have to tell you about love and marriage: nothing,

like a book without pages or a forest without trees.

Because there are things you cannot know before you experience them.
Because no study can prepare you for the joys or the trials.
Because nobody else's love, nobody else's marriage, is like yours,
and it's a road you can only learn by walking it,
a dance you cannot be taught,
a song that did not exist before you began, together, to sing.

And because in the darkness you will reach out a hand,
not knowing for certain if someone else is even there.
And your hands will meet,
and then neither of you will ever need to be alone again.

And that's all I know about love.

A quote from John Muir

The sun shines not on us but in us. The rivers flow not past us, but through us.
Thrilling, tingling, vibrating every fiber and cell of the substance of our bodies,
making them glide and sing. The trees wave and the flowers bloom in our bodies as
well as our souls, and every bird song, wind song, and tremendous storm song in
the heart of the mountains is our song, our very own, and sings our love.

From "Captain Correlli's Mandolin" by Louis de Bernieres

Love is a temporary madness, it erupts like volcanoes and then subsides.
And when it subsides you have to make a decision.
You have to work out whether your root was so entwined together that it is
Inconceivable that you should ever part.
Because this is what love is.
Love is not breathlessness, it is not excitement,
It is not the promulgation of promises of eternal passion.
That is just being in love, which any fool can do.
Love itself is what is left over when being in love has burned away,
And this is both an art and a fortunate accident...
To have roots that grow towards each other underground,
So that when all the pretty blossoms have fallen from your branches,
You find that you are one tree and not two.

"Love" by Roy Croft

I love you
Not only for what you are,
But for what I am

When I am with you.

I love you,
Not only for what
You have made of yourself,
But for what
You are making of me.

I love you
For the part of me
That you bring out;

I love you
For putting your hand
Into my heaped-up heart
And passing over

All the foolish, weak things
That you can't help but
Dimly see there,
And for drawing out
Into the light
All the beautiful belongings
That no one else had looked
Quite far enough to find.

I love you because you
Are helping me to make
Of the lumber of my life
Not a tavern
But a temple.

Out of the works
Of my every day
Not a reproach
But a song.

I love you
Because you have done
More than any creed
Could have done
To make me good.
And more than any fate
Could have done
To make me happy (con'td...)

You have done it
Without a touch,
Without a word,

Without a sign.

You have done it
By being yourself.

And when all is said and done
Isn't that what love is after all?

From The Bridge Across Forever by Richard Bach

"A soul mate is someone who has locks that fit our keys, and keys to fit our locks. When we feel safe enough to open the locks, our truest selves step out and we can be completely and honestly who we are; we can be loved for who we are and not for who we're pretending to be. Each unveils the best part of the other. No matter what else goes wrong around us, with that one person we're safe in our own paradise. Our soul mate is someone who shares our deepest longings, our sense of direction. When we're two balloons, and together our direction is up, chances are we've found the right person. Our soul mate is the one who makes life come to life."

"Marry Your Best Friend" by N'Tima Preusser

Marry your best friend. I do not say that lightly. Really, truly find the strongest, happiest friendship in the person you fall in love with. Someone who speaks highly of you. Someone you can laugh with. The kind of laughs that make your belly ache, and your nose snort. The embarrassing, earnest, healing kind of laughs. Wit is important. Life is too short not to love someone who lets you be a fool with them. Make sure they are somebody who lets you cry, too. Despair will come. Find someone that you want to be there with you through those times. Most importantly, marry the one that makes passion, love and madness combine and course through you. A love that will never dilute - even when the waters get deep, and dark.

Words from from Carl Sagan

"The size and age of the Cosmos are beyond ordinary human understanding. Lost somewhere between immensity and eternity is our tiny planetary home. Our little planet floats like a mote of dust in the morning sky. All that you see, all that we can see, exploded out of a star billions of years ago, and the particles slowly arranged themselves into living things, including all of us. We are made of star stuff. We are the mechanism by which the universe can comprehend itself. The world is so exquisite with so much love and moral depth. We should remain grateful every day for the brief but magnificent opportunity that life provides. The sum of all our evolution, our thinking and our accomplishments is love. A marriage makes two fractional lives a whole. It gives to two questioning natures a renewed reason for living. It brings a new gladness to the sunshine, a new fragrance to the flowers, a new beauty to the earth, a new mystery to life."

Blessing of the Hands - anonymous

Love each other from this day forward, and these will be the hands that you hold tomorrow, and the next day, and into the next decade.

These are the hands that will work alongside yours as you build your life together, the hands that will touch you with love and tenderness through the years, and the hands that will comfort you like no others' can. These are the hands that will hold you through grief, fear, and hardship. These are the hands that will wipe tears of joy and sorrow from your eyes, and the hands that will tenderly hold your children. These are the hands that will hold your family together, and that will give you strength when you need it. These are the hands, that when wrinkled and spotted with age, will still be reaching for yours, still giving you the same unspoken tenderness with just a touch.

"The Undeniable Miracle" by John Mark Green

In you,
I have finally found all I
never dared to dream I could
deserve or have - the kind
of love that is rare.
Being known in a way that
touches the deepest parts
of me. Accepted in a way
that blows my mind.

In you,
the love I have always
desired to give now has a
place to call home. I have
been a skeptic, but you are
my undeniable miracle.
The questions don't matter
anymore. We have finally
found each other, and that
is enough.

Isaiah 54, Chapter 11

*I will rebuild you with stones of turquoise, your foundations with lapis lazuli
I will make your battlements of rubies, your gates of sparkling jewels, and all your
walls of precious stones.
All your children will be taught by the Lord and great will be their peace.
Tyranny will be far from you; you will have nothing to fear.
Terror will be far removed; it will not come near you
For the mountains may move and the hills disappear, but even my faithful love for
you will remain.*

**From the book "True Love" by Robert Fulghum, p. 98
(*Not* from Dr. Seuss as most of the internet thinks it's from!)**

"We're all a little weird and life's a little weird and when we find someone whose weirdness is compatible with ours, we join up with them and fall into mutual weirdness and call it true love."

An actual quote from Dr. Seuss :)

"You know you're in love when you can't fall asleep because reality is finally better than your dreams."

"The Beginning to End" – Robert Fulghum

You have known each other from the first glance of acquaintance to this point of commitment. At some point, you decided to marry. From that moment of yes to this moment of yes, indeed, you have been making promises and agreements in an informal way. All those conversations that were held riding in a car or over a meal or during long walks — all those sentences that began with "When we're married" and continued with "I will and you will and we will"- those late night talks that included "someday" and "somehow" and "maybe"- and all those promises that are unspoken matters of the heart. All these common things, and more, are the real process of a wedding. The symbolic exchange that you are about to make is a way of saying to one another, " You know all those things we've promised and hoped and dreamed- well, I meant it all, every word." Look at one another and remember this moment in time. Before this moment you have been many things to one another- acquaintance, friend, companion, lover, and even teacher, for you have learned much from one another in these last few years. Now you shall say a few words that take you across a threshold of life, and things will never quite be the same between you. For after this, you shall say to the world, "this- is my husband," and "this- is my wife."

(*Note: I can change partner gender wording here if you are a same sex couple :)

"The Wedding Poem" by Neil Gaiman

This for you, for both of you,
a small poem of happiness
filled with small glories and little triumphs
a fragile, short cheerful song
filled with hope and all sorts of futures

Because at weddings we imagine the future
Because it's all about "what happened next?"
all the work and negotiation and building and talk

that makes even the tiniest happily ever after
something to be proud of for a wee forever

This is a small thought for both of you
like a feather or a prayer,
a wish of trust and love and hope
and fine brave hearts and true.

Like a tower, or a house made all of bones and dreams
and tomorrows and tomorrows and tomorrows

"Mysteries, Yes" by Mary Oliver...

Truly, we live with mysteries too marvelous
to be understood.
How grass can be nourishing in the
mouths of the lambs.
How rivers and stones are forever
in allegiance with gravity
while we ourselves dream of rising.
How two hands touch and the bonds
will never be broken.
How people come, from delight or the
scars of damage,
to the comfort of a poem.
Let me keep my distance, always, from those
who think they have the answers.
Let me keep company always with those who say
"Look!" and laugh in astonishment,
and bow their heads.

"Atlas" by U.A. Fanthorpe

There is a kind of love called maintenance
Which stores the WD40 and knows when to use it;
Which checks the insurance, and doesn't forget
The milkman; which remembers to plant bulbs;
Which answers letters; which knows the way
The money goes; which deals with dentists
And Road Fund Tax and meeting trains,
And postcards to the lonely; which upholds
The permanently rickety elaborate
Structures of living, which is Atlas.
And maintenance is the sensible side of love,
Which knows what time and weather are doing
To my brickwork; insulates my faulty wiring;

Laughs at my dryrotten jokes; remembers
My need for gloss and grouting; which keeps
My suspect edifice upright in air,
As Atlas did the sky.

"I Carry Your Heart with Me" – e.e. cummings

I carry your heart with me (I carry it in my heart).
I am never without it.
(Anywhere I go you go, my dear,
And whatever done by only me is your doing, my darling)
I fear no fate (for you are my fate, my sweet).
I want no world (for beautiful you are my world, my true).
And it's you are whatever a moon has always meant,
And whatever a sun will always sing is you.

Here is the deepest secret nobody knows...
(Here is the root of the root and the bud of the bud
And the sky of the sky of a tree called life which grows higher than soul can hope or
mind can hide).
And this is the wonder that's keeping the stars apart.
I carry your heart with me (I carry it in my heart).

An excerpt from the United States Supreme Court ruling summary in Obergefell v. Hodges - the case that ruled that the fundamental right to marry is guaranteed to same-sex couples. It says...

The dynamic of marriage allows two people to find a life that could not be found alone, for a marriage becomes greater than just the two persons. Rising from the most basic human needs, marriage is essential to our most profound hopes and aspirations. No union is more profound than marriage, for it embodies the highest ideals of love, fidelity, devotion, sacrifice, and family. In forming a marital union, two people become something greater than once they were. Marriage embodies a love that may endure even past death.

The idea that some are disrespecting marriage by entering into this union is quite the contrary, as they respect the idea of marriage so deeply that they seek to find its fulfillment for themselves. All they are asking for is EQUAL dignity in the eyes of the law.

Corinthians 13: 4-7

Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud. It does not dishonor others, it is not self-seeking, it is not easily angered, it keeps no record of wrongs. Love does not delight in evil but rejoices with the truth. It always protects, always trusts, always hopes, always perseveres.

From "The Alchemist" by Paulo Coelho

"We are travelers on a cosmic journey, stardust, swirling and dancing in the eddies and whirlpools of infinity. Life is eternal. We have stopped for a moment to encounter each other, to meet, to love, to share. This is a precious moment. It is a little parenthesis in eternity."

Another from "The Alchemist" by Paulo Coelho

(We can adapt this reading to change the pronouns for same-sex couples)

"When he looked into her dark eyes, and saw that her lips were poised between a laugh and silence, he learned the most important part of the language that all the world spoke -- the language that everyone on earth was capable of understanding in their heart. It was love. Something older than humanity, more ancient than the desert. Something that exerted the same force whenever two pairs of eyes met, as had theirs...

It was the pure Language of the World. It required no explanation, just as the universe needs none as it travels through endless time... when you know that language, it's easy to understand that someone in the world awaits you, whether it's in the middle of the desert or in some great city. And when two such people encounter each other, and their eyes meet, the past and the future become unimportant. There is only that moment, and the incredible certainty that everything under the sun has been written by one hand only. It is the hand that evokes love, and creates a twin soul for every person in the world."

Words from Rumi

"The minute I heard my first love story,
I started looking for you, not knowing
how blind that was.
Lovers don't finally meet somewhere.
They're in each other all along."

Words from Pablo Neruda

"I love your feet
because they have
wandered over
the earth and through
the wind and water
until they brought

you to me."

"All I Ever Really Needed to Know I Learned in Kindergarten," by Robert Fulghum

All of what I really need to know about how to live, and what to do, and how to be, I learned in Kindergarten. Wisdom was not at the top of the graduate school mountain, but there in the sandbox at nursery school. These are the things I learned...

Share everything.
Play fair.
Don't hit people.
Put things back where you found them.
Clean up your own mess.
Don't take things that aren't yours.
Say sorry when you hurt somebody.
Wash your hands before you eat.
Flush.
Warm cookies and cold milk are good for you.
Give them to someone who feels sad.
Live a balanced life.
Learn some and think some and draw and paint and sing and dance and play and work every day.
Take a nap every afternoon.
Be aware of wonder.

Remember the little seed in the plastic cup?
The roots go down and the plant goes up and nobody really knows how or why, but we are all like that.
Everything you need to know is in there somewhere.
And it is still true, no matter how old you are, when you go out into the world, it is best to hold hands and stick together.

**Either From "Shaman's Circle" by Nancy Wood
Or it's called "Distant Shores" by Carol Shivers**
(Different sources say different origins)

Before we met, you and I were halves unjoined except in the wide rivers of our minds. We were each other's distant shore, the opposite wings of a bird, the other half of a seashell. We did not know the other then, did not know our determination to keep alive the cry of one riverbank to the other. We were apart, yet connected in our ignorance of each other, like two apples sharing a common tree. Remember? I knew you existed long before you understood my desire to join my freedom to yours. Our paths collided long enough for our indecision to be swallowed up by the greater need of love.

When you came to me, the sun surged towards the earth and the moon escaped from darkness to bless the union of two spirits so alike that the creator had designed them for life's endless circle. Beloved partner, keeper of my heart's odd secrets, clothed in summer blossoms so the icy hand of winter never touches us. I thank your patience. Our joining is like a tree to earth, a cloud to sky and even more. We are the reason the world can laugh on its battlefields and rise from the ashes of its selfishness to hear me say, in this time, this place, this way – I loved you best of all.

"We Two, How Long We Were Fool'd" by Walt Whitman.

We two, how long we were fool'd,
Now transmuted, we swiftly escape as Nature escapes,
We are Nature, long have we been absent, but now we return,
We become plants, trunks, foliage, roots, bark,
We are bedded in the ground, we are rocks,
We are oaks, we grow in the openings side by side,
We browse, we are two among the wild herds spontaneous as any,
We are two fishes swimming in the sea together,
We are what locust blossoms are, we drop scent around lanes mornings and evenings,
We are also the coarse smut of beasts, vegetables, minerals,
We are two predatory hawks, we soar above and look down,
We are two resplendent suns, we it is who balance ourselves orbic and stellar, we are as two comets,
We prowl fang'd and four-footed in the woods, we spring on prey,
We are two clouds forenoons and afternoons driving overhead,
We are seas mingling, we are two of those cheerful waves rolling over each other and interwetting each other,
We are what the atmosphere is, transparent, receptive, pervious, impervious,
We are snow, rain, cold, darkness, we are each product and influence of the globe,
We have circled and circled till we have arrived home again, we two,
We have voided all but freedom and all but our own joy.

From "The Velveteen Rabbit" by Margery Williams

'What is REAL?' asked the Rabbit one day, when they were lying side by side near the nursery fender, before Nana came to tidy the room. 'Does it mean having things that buzz inside you and a stick-out handle?' 'Real isn't how you are made,' said the Skin Horse. 'It's a thing that happens to you. When someone loves you for a long, long time, not just to play with, but REALLY loves you, then you become Real.' 'Does it hurt?' asked the Rabbit. 'Sometimes,' said the Skin Horse, for he was always truthful. 'When you are Real you don't mind being hurt.' 'Does it happen all at once, like being wound up,' he asked, 'or bit by bit?' 'It doesn't happen all at once,' said the Skin Horse. 'You become. It takes a long time. That's why it doesn't happen often to people who break easily, or have sharp edges, or who have to be carefully kept. Generally, by the time you are Real, most of your hair has been

loved off, and your eyes drop out and you get loose in your joints and very shabby. But these things don't matter at all, because once you are Real you can't be ugly, except to people who don't understand... and once you are Real you can't become unreal again. It lasts for always.'

The Invitation - Oriah Mountain Dreamer

"It doesn't interest me what you do for a living. I want to know what you ache for and if you dare to dream of meeting your heart's longing.

It doesn't interest me how old you are. I want to know if you will risk looking like a fool for love, for your dream, for the adventure of being alive.

It doesn't interest me what planets are squaring your moon. I want to know if you have touched the centre of your own sorrow, if you have been opened by life's betrayals or have become shrivelled and closed from fear of further pain.

I want to know if you can sit with pain, mine or your own, without moving to hide it, or fade it, or fix it.

I want to know if you can be with joy, mine or your own; if you can dance with wildness and let the ecstasy fill you to the tips of your fingers and toes without cautioning us to be careful, be realistic, remember the limitations of being human.

It doesn't interest me if the story you are telling me is true. I want to know if you can disappoint another to be true to yourself. If you can bear the accusation of betrayal and not betray your own soul. If you can be faithless and therefore trustworthy.

I want to know if you can see Beauty even when it is not pretty every day. And if you can source your own life from its presence.

I want to know if you can live with failure, yours and mine, and still stand at the edge of the lake and shout to the silver of the full moon, 'Yes.'

It doesn't interest me to know where you live or how much money you have. I want to know if you can get up after the night of grief and despair, weary and bruised to the bone and do what needs to be done to feed the children.

It doesn't interest me who you know or how you came to be here. I want to know if you will stand in the centre of the fire with me and not shrink back.

It doesn't interest me where or what or with whom you have studied. I want to know what sustains you from the inside when all else falls away.

I want to know if you can be alone with yourself and if you truly like the company you keep in the empty moments."

Quote from Julie Dillon

"Our universe grants every soul a twin - a reflection of themselves - the kindred spirit - and no matter where they are or how far away they are from each other, even in different dimensions, they will always find one another. This is destiny; this is love."

From Pope Francis' Address of the Holy Father on Sept. 26th, 2015

"Love is something we learn; love is something we live; love grows as it is "forged" by the concrete situations which each particular family experiences. Love is born and constantly develops amid lights and shadows. Love can flourish in men and women who try not to make conflict the last word, but rather a new opportunity. An opportunity to seek help, an opportunity to question how we need to improve, an opportunity to discover the God who is with us and never abandons us."

A quote from Johnny Cash

I love you because you understand, dear
Every little thing I do.
You're always there to lend a helping hand, dear
But most of all I love you 'cause you're you.

Song of Solomon, Chapter 8, Verses 6 - 7

Set me as a seal upon your heart,
as a seal upon your arm;
for love is strong as death,
passion fierce as the grave.
Its flashes are flashes of fire,
a raging flame.
Many waters cannot quench love,
neither can floods drown it.
If one offered for love
all the wealth of his house,
it would be utterly scorned.

One Hundred Love Sonnets: XVII by Pablo Neruda

I don't love you as if you were a rose of salt, topaz,
or arrow of carnations that propagate fire:
I love you as one loves certain obscure things,
secretly, between the shadow and the soul.

I love you as the plant that doesn't bloom but carries

the light of those flowers, hidden, within itself,
and thanks to your love the tight aroma that arose
from the earth lives dimly in my body.

I love you without knowing how, or when, or from where,
I love you directly without problems or pride:
I love you like this because I don't know any other way to love,
except in this form in which I am not nor are you,
so close that your hand upon my chest is mine,
so close that your eyes close with my dreams.

A writing by Carl Sandburg

"I love you for what you are, but I love you yet more for what you are going to be. I love you not so much for your realities as for your ideals. I pray for your desires that they may be great, rather than for your satisfactions, which may be so hazardingly little. A satisfied flower is one whose petals are about to fall. The most beautiful rose is one hardly more than a bud wherein the pangs and ecstasies of desires are working for larger and finer growth. Not always shall you be what you are now. You are going forward toward something great. I am on the way with you and therefore I love you."

A quote from The Passion by Jeanette Winterson

"I think now that being free is not being powerful or rich or well-regarded or without obligation, but being able to love. To love someone else enough to forget about yourself even for one moment is to be free."

To Love Is Not To Possess - James Kavanaugh

To love is not to possess,
To own or imprison,
Nor to lose one's self in another.
Love is to join and separate,
To walk alone and together,
To find a laughing freedom
That lonely isolation does not permit.
It is finally to be able
To be who we really are
No longer clinging in childish dependency
Nor docilely living separate lives in silence,
It is to be perfectly one's self
And perfectly joined in permanent commitment
To another--and to one's inner self.
Love only endures when it moves like waves,
Receding and returning gently or passionately,

Or moving lovingly like the tide
In the moon's own predictable harmony,
Because finally, despite a child's scars
Or an adult's deepest wounds,
They are openly free to be
Who they really are--and always secretly were,
In the very core of their being
Where true and lasting love can alone abide.

"If Life is a Question Mark" by Tyler Knott Gregson

What if all we have ever wanted isn't hiding in some secret and far away dream but inside of us now as we breathe one another and find home in the way our arms always seem to fit perfectly around the spaces between us?

What if we are the answer and love is the question? What if all this time it was us you were supposed to find? I am filled with wonderings and questions and doubt but of one thing I am certain: it will always be you that gives flight to the butterflies inside me, calm to the sea I have become and hope to the darkness all around us. It is you and it has always been you...

You that soothes and excites and spreads joy like rainfall on the already damp earth; You that pulled me from the longest sleep and kissed my tired eyelids awake. If life were a question mark, then you my love are the proud and bold period that is typed with certainty.

A reading from "Wild Awake" by Hilary T. Smith. It says:

"People are like cities: We all have alleys and gardens and secret rooftops and places where daisies sprout between the sidewalk cracks, but most of the time all we let each other see is a postcard glimpse of a skyline or a polished square. Love lets you find those hidden places in another person, even the ones they didn't know were there, even the ones they wouldn't have thought to call beautiful themselves."

An excerpt by Victoria Erickson

When connections are real, they simply never die. They can be buried, or ignored or walked away from, but never broken. If you've deeply resonated with another person or place, the connection remains despite any distance, time, situation, lack of presence or circumstance. If you're doubtful then just try it - go and revisit a person or place and see if there's any sense at all of the space between now and then. If it was truly real, you'll be instantly swept back into the moment it was before it left - during the same year and place with the same wonder and hope, comfort and heartbeat. Real connections live on forever.

Ecclesiastes 4: 9-12

Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor: If either of them falls down, one can help the other up. But woe to anyone who falls and has no one to help them up. Also, if two lie down together, they will keep warm. But how can one keep warm alone? Though one may be overpowered, two can defend themselves, and a cord of three strands is not quickly broken.

From the show "The Good Witch" (original author may be different)

They're about to say I do,
Three little letters, two little words.
It's the simplest part of the day but there's nothing simple
about the things that will remain unsaid.
I do means, "I do know I could be hurt, but I'm ready to be healed with you."
It means, "I do want to try even when the fear of failure holds me back,
and I do not know the future, but I'm ready to be surprised along the way."
And I do means, "I do want your love and I do give you mine,
and nothing we do will ever be the same because you and I will be doing it all
together."

"On Marriage" by Kahlil Gibran

You were born together, and together you shall be forevermore.
You shall be together when the white wings of death scatter your days.
Ay, you shall be together even in the silent memory of God.
But let there be spaces in your togetherness,
And let the winds of the heavens dance between you.

Love one another, but make not a bond of love:
Let it rather be a moving sea between the shores of your souls.
Fill each other's cup but drink not from one cup.
Give one another of your bread but eat not from the same loaf
Sing and dance together and be joyous, but let each one of you be alone,
Even as the strings of a lute are alone though they quiver with the same music.

Give your hearts, but not into each other's keeping.
For only the hand of Life can contain your hearts.
And stand together yet not too near together:
For the pillars of the temple stand apart,
And the oak tree and the cypress grow not in each other's shadow.

"How Falling In Love Is Like Owning A Dog" by Taylor Mali

On cold winter nights, love is warm.
It lies between you and lives and breathes
and makes funny noises.
Love wakes you up all hours of the night with its needs.
It needs to be fed so it will grow and stay healthy.
Love doesn't like being left alone for long.
But come home and love is always happy to see you.
It may break a few things accidentally in its passion for life,
but you can never be mad at love for long.
Is love good all the time? No! No!
Love can be bad. Bad, love, bad! Very bad love.
Love makes messes.
Love leaves you little surprises here and there.
Love needs lots of cleaning up after.
Sometimes you just want to get love fixed.
Sometimes you want to roll up a piece of newspaper
and swat love on the nose,
not so much to cause pain,
just to let love know Don't you ever do that again!
Sometimes love just wants to go out for a nice long walk.
Because love loves exercise. It will run you around the block
and leave you panting, breathless. Pull you in different directions
at once, or wind itself around and around you
until you're all wound up and you cannot move.
But love makes you meet people wherever you go.
People who have nothing in common but love
stop and talk to each other on the street.
Throw things away and love will bring them back,
again, and again, and again.
But most of all, love needs love, lots of it.
And in return, love loves you and never stops.

The Desiderata - Max Ehrmann

Go placidly amid the noise and haste, and remember what peace there may be in silence.

As far as possible without surrender be on good terms with all persons.

Speak your truth quietly and clearly; and listen to others, they too have their story.

Enjoy your achievements as well as your plans.

Be yourself.

Especially, do not feign affection.

Neither be critical about love; for in the face of all aridity and disenchantment it is as perennial as the grass.

Take kindly the counsel of the years, gracefully surrendering the things of youth.

Nurture strength of spirit to shield you in sudden misfortune. But do not distress yourself with imaginings. Many fears are born of fatigue and loneliness.

Beyond a wholesome discipline, be gentle with yourself.

You are a child of the universe, no less than the trees and the stars; you have a right to be here. And whether or not it is clear to you, no doubt the universe is unfolding as it should.

Whatever your labors and aspirations, in the noisy confusion of life keep peace with your soul. With all its sham, drudgery and broken dreams, it is still a beautiful world. Strive to be happy.

Quote from Maya Angelou

My great hope is to laugh as much as I cry; to get my work done and try to love somebody and have the courage to accept the love in return.

Author Unknown

"To love a person is to see all of their magic, and to remind them of it when they have forgotten."

Quote from Lao Tsu

Being deeply loved by someone gives you strength, while loving someone deeply gives you courage.

From "The Last Battle" by C.S. Lewis

"Now at last they were beginning Chapter One of the Great Story which no one on earth has read: which goes on for ever: in which every chapter is better than the one before."

And this woman has a page with a lot of cool and unusual readings:

<http://www.asimpleceremony.org/readings/>

BLESSINGS WITH A SPIRITUAL FEEL THAT ARE COMMON IN THE WEDDING WORLD

The following are examples of blessings commonly found when you Google “wedding reading” or “wedding blessing”. I’ve always wondered “where do these blessings actually come from... are they truly from the attributed culture of origin?” So I did a bit more research about the background of these particular readings, and their true origins. There are of course many more out there than what I’ve listed, so the goal here is to help you explore which style might fit you if you want a blessing that has a particular spiritual feel...

*Note: If you’ve been thinking about using the “Apache Wedding Blessing” which has been wildly popular on the internet in recent years, make sure to read p. 23!

“A Blessing for the Journey”

- Wendy Egyoku Nakao, Abbot of the Zen Center of Los Angeles

This blessing often shows up in the world of weddings as “Buddhist Prayer”, so it might seem that it’s been around for generations. In fact, it was written relatively recently by Wendy Egyoku Nakao who is the Abbot of a Zen Center in Los Angeles. If this type of an eastern-based religious style is resonant for you, this is an example of a blessing you might use, or let me know if you’d like more ideas, and we can explore additional sources that are authentic and that we can add into your ceremony in such a way that honors the particular Buddhist or eastern religion.

*Let us vow to bear witness to the wholeness of life,
realizing the completeness of each and every thing.
Embracing our differences,
I shall know myself as you,
and you as myself.
May we serve each other
for all our days,
here, there, and everywhere.
Let us vow to open ourselves to the abundance of life.
Freely giving and receiving, I shall care for you,
for the trees and stars,
as treasures of my very own.
May we be grateful
for all our days,
here, there, and everywhere.
Let us vow to forgive all hurt,
caused by ourselves and others,
and to never condone hurtful ways.
Being responsible for my actions,
I shall free myself and you.
May we be kind*

*for all our days,
here, there, and everywhere.
Let us vow to remember that all that appears will disappear.
In the midst of uncertainty,
I shall sow love.
Let us together live
The Great Peace that we are.
May we give no fear
for all our days,
here, there, and everywhere.*

“Namaste” by Rajender Krishan:

This simple word,
uttered with a gesture of folded hands,
is among the finest salutations
mankind has ever been able to vocalize.
It simply means:
I honor the place in you
in which the entire Universe dwells.
That place of Love and Light
and of Truth and of Peace.
When you are in that place in you
And I am in that place in me,
We are One.

The Seven Blessings from the Jewish tradition

This is just one of many versions of the Seven Blessings in the Jewish tradition. If Judaism is in your heritage, and you want to incorporate something like the Seven Blessings into your ceremony, you can explore the link below, plus Google around to see what you find, and let me know what resonates with you as a couple.

*May you be generous and giving with each other.
May your sense of humor and playful spirit always continue to enliven your relationship.
May you always respect the diversity of humankind.
May you act with compassion to those less fortunate and with responsibility to the communities of which you are a part.
May you appreciate and complement each other's differences.
May you always share yourselves openly with your friends and family.
May your home be a haven of blessing and peace*

several other interpretations of the Seven Blessings:
https://interfaithfamily.com/life_cycle/weddings/the_seven_blessings/

Celtic/Irish or Buddhist?

Some internet sources show this as Buddhist & some as Celtic

I have to do more research to determine which, but still thought I'd include it since many couples have brought it to me :)

You cannot possess me, for I belong to myself.
But while we both wish it,
I give you that which is mine to give.
You cannot command me,
for I am a free person.
But I shall serve you
in those ways you require,
and the honeycomb will taste sweeter
coming from my hand.
I pledge to you that yours will be
the name I cry aloud in the night,
and the eyes into which I smile in the morning.
I pledge to you the first bite of my meat,
and the first drink from my cup.
I pledge to you my living and my dying,
each equally in your care.
I shall be a shield for your back,
and you for mine.
I shall not slander you,
nor you me.
I shall honor you above all others.
This is my wedding vow to you.
This is the marriage of equals.

Blessings with an Irish or Celtic Feel

The following examples often show up in the world of weddings as traditional Irish or Celtic blessings. Upon Googling around to learn about the original sources, the jury is still out on the true origin of these types of sayings. If you have more information, let me know, and for now we'll just say that these are blessings that invoke a particular flavor or "feel" of the Irish and Celtic traditions.

*May you both live as long as you want, and never want as long as you live.
In love, life and happiness, may your troubles be few and your blessings plenty.
May the raindrops fall lightly on your brow
May the soft winds freshen your spirit
May the sunshine brighten your heart
May the burdens of the day rest lightly upon you
And may Mother Earth enfold you in the mantle of her love.
May the road rise to meet you*

*May the wind be always at your back
And may the longtime sun shine on you, all love surround you, and the pure light
within you, guide you on your way.*

And another example...

*May flowers always line your path and sunshine light your day
May song birds serenade you every step along the way.
May a rainbow run beside you in a sky that's always blue,
And may happiness fill your hearts each day, your whole life through.*

Blessings with a Christian feel...

*Bless this marriage, O God, as _____ and _____ begin their journey down the road of
life together. We don't know what lies ahead for the road turns and bends. But help
them to make the best of whatever comes their way.*

*Help them to hug each other often, talk and laugh a lot. Help them to continue to
enjoy each other as they did when they first met. Help them to realize that nothing
nor no one is perfect and to look for the good in all things and all people including
themselves. Help them to respect each other's likes and dislikes, opinion and
beliefs, hopes and dreams and fears. Help them to learn from each other and to
help each other to grow mentally, emotionally, and spiritually.*

*Help them to realize that there is design and purpose in their lives as in the world,
and if they will hold onto each other, they will know that things have a way of
working out for the good. Amen. - "A Marriage Prayer" by Bud Henry Bowmen*

~~*~*~*

*May your marriage always bring glory to God, joy to one another and blessings to
your family for many generations to come. May love and laughter fill your hearts
and your home for all at the days of your lives. May you face every challenge hand-
in-hand and side-by-side knowing that with God's grace, you'll conquer all obstacles
together. May the world be forever a better place because the two of you fell in
love. In Jesus' name, Amen. - Blessing by Pastor Dave Willis*

~~*~*~*

*Let us pray: Heavenly Father, we ask you to bless all who are gathered here, and to
bless and sanctify our purpose in marriage today. Please God, bless this woman
and man who make their vows before you. Grant that this marriage be a rich and
purposeful union, a true blending of hearts and souls. Awaken always in them the
gifts that they each bring to make this marriage strong and beautiful, that they
may live and grow together in love for the rest of their days to come. Amen.
- From traditional prayers Officiant Lisa has adapted over the years.*

Some examples of blessings with an Inter-Spiritual Feel that I've written for couples over the years...

These aren't from the internet, but are some good examples of blessings that can be created by interweaving different recipes and flavors of spiritual styles. Just let me know what's important to you, and I can make one for you that is similar to these examples, or create an entirely new one from scratch. Or, make your own!

You both have described your belief in something larger – a power within you that guides you through the world, a deep knowing and deep centeredness that allows you to live in the present moment and respond to life in the Now with compassion, humility and love – that which you may call by many names - God, Higher Self, Atma, Universal Mind, Divine Mother, Spirit, Love - with the witness of this divine presence and of your community of family and friends, we begin and bless this ceremony today.

~~*~*

We ask for your blessing, Father Mother God All That Is, please bless each of us here and please bless this marriage with the same grace and love that created these trees, these birds, this big open Colorado sky, these mountains and this dear circle of family and friends. Father Mother God All That Is, please bless _____ and _____ to live this moment fully, seeding a lifetime of abundance, happiness, health and love for the rest of their years to come. Please bless them to support each other through life's joys and challenges, to continue to grow together as they walk their shared path, and to enjoy this path while truly present and fully alive.

~~*~*

We are here, on this mountain top, where earth and trees and water and rock are so visibly interconnected, because it reminds you of the divine universal energy that connects all of life, and also of the inextricable connection you feel with your family and friends here today. And so we begin.

About the "Apache" Wedding Blessing and other blessings with an Earth-Based Feel

When you Google "wedding readings", the following blessing will likely come up entitled as something like "Apache or Cherokee" wedding blessing. Turns out, this blessing is not of Native American origin - it is from the book "Blood Brother" written in 1947 by Elliot Arnold, and then later adapted into the movie "Broken Arrow." The book is "ethnographic fiction", meaning that Arnold created a fictional story based on information that he gathered about Native American culture at the time (you can read more about the different perspectives on the validity of his ethnographic information if you Google around). In the story, a wedding takes place and this blessing is shared, which Arnold has explained is a completely fictional blessing that he wrote himself. The original text in the book was this:

*"Now for you there is no rain
For one is shelter to the other.
Now for you there is no sun
for one is shelter to the other.
Now for you nothing is hard or bad,
For the hardness and badness is taken by one for the other."*

The form that is popular in the wedding world is adapted from the movie:

*"Now you will feel no rain, for each of you will be shelter for the other.
Now you will feel no cold, for each of you will be warmth to the other.
Now there will be no loneliness, for each of you will be companion to the other.
Now you are two persons, but there is only one life before you.
May beauty surround you both in the journey ahead and through all the years.
May happiness be your companion and your days together be good and long upon the earth."*

It is important to know the origin of this reading. If we were to use it in your script, we would not refer to it as a Native American blessing, but rather an excerpt from Elliot Arnold's book or from the movie "Broken Arrow".

I believe the popularity of this blessing is in some ways related to a general yearning for earth-based wisdom in our culture, plus a romanticization of Native American culture. My thought is that the romanticization of Native American culture is something to avoid, while the yearning for earth-based wisdom is healthy and authentic, and if you would like some in your ceremony, let's create from scratch an earth-based blessing that is your very own. This is a meaningful process, during which you can reflect on the elements and types of earth wisdom that have inspired you in your own connections with nature, and we can craft those inspirations into a wedding blessing expressly for the two of you.

Here is another example of a popular blessing that is referred to as "Native American" in the wedding world, but actually is of unknown origin. You can refer to it, and other examples on the internet, as inspiration for us to craft an earth-based blessing that is authentic to you...

Great Spirit protect the ones we love.

*We honor all you have created as this couple pledges
their hearts and lives to one another.
We honor the earth - and ask that this marriage
be abundant and grow stronger through the seasons;
We honor fire - and ask that this union
be warm and glowing with love;
We honor wind - and ask that this marriage
be safe and calm as in a parent's arms;
We honor water - to cleanse and soothe the relationship,
that it may never thirst for love.*

Amen.

And here is another example for inspiration to create an earth-based prayer - this is a blessing that is simply earth-based while not claiming to be Native American. It is adapted from a baby blessing ceremony by Mark Belletini who is a Unitarian Universalist minister...

We bless this couple with the elements of our common being, with earth, air, fire and water. (Officiant lifts a handful of earth before the couple) With earth, we bless you. Take care of your bodies, be open and receptive to what nourishes and sustains you, for you are a gift of the earth.

(Officiant dips fingers into a small bowl of warm water and touches them gently to the crown of their heads) With water, we bless you. May you be open to the gift of your emotions, and may you learn the power of acceptance, and the strength of gentleness.

(Officiant holds a candle flame aloft before the couple's eyes) With fire, we bless you. May your minds be illuminated and your hearts filled with a deep knowing of love. May you think clearly, act wisely, and love fully through all the days of your life.

(Officiant gently waves a pine bough or other object around the couple) With air, we bless you. May you hear the voice of spirit in your life, guiding and directing your every step, watching over you and comforting you, and reminding you always that you will never be alone.

LONGER WRITINGS ABOUT MARRIAGE

Words from Pierre Tielhart de Chardin

"Love is an adventure and a conquest. It survives and develops like the universe itself only by perpetual discovery. The only right love is that between couples whose passion leads them both, one through the other, to a higher possession of their being. Put your faith in the spirit which dwells between the two of you. You have each offered yourself to the other as a boundless field of understanding, of enrichment, of mutually increased sensibility. You will meet above all by entering into and constantly sharing one another's thoughts, affections, and dreams. There alone, as you know, in spirit, which is arrived through flesh, you will find no disappointments, no limits. There alone the skies are ever open for your love; there alone lies the great road ahead."

An excerpt from "The Irrational Season" by Madeline L'Engle

"Ultimately there comes a time when a decision must be made. Ultimately two people who love each other must ask themselves how much they hope for as their love grows and deepens, and how much risk they are willing to take. It is indeed a fearful gamble. Because it is the nature of love to create, a marriage itself is something which has to be created. To marry is the biggest risk in human relations that a person can take. If we commit ourselves to one person for life this is not, as many people think, a rejection of freedom; rather it demands the courage to move into all the risks of freedom, and the risk of love which is permanent; into that love which is not possession, but participation. It takes a lifetime to learn another person. When love is not possession, but participation, then it is part of that co-creation which is our human calling."

Reading by Edmund O'Neil called "Marriage Joins Two People in the Circle of Its Love".

"Marriage is a commitment to life, the best that two people can find and bring out in each other. It offers opportunities for sharing and growth that no other relationship can equal. It is a physical and an emotional joining that is promised for a lifetime. Within the circle of its love, marriage encompasses all of life's most important relationships. The two partners are each other's best friend, confidant, lover, teacher, listener, and critic. And there may come times when one partner is heartbroken or ailing, and the love of the other may resemble the tender caring of a parent for a child. Marriage deepens and enriches every facet of life. Happiness is fuller, memories are fresher, commitment is stronger, even anger is felt more strongly, and passes away more quickly. Marriage understands and forgives the mistakes life is unable to avoid. It encourages and nurtures new life, new experiences, and new ways of expressing a love that is deeper than life. When two people pledge their love and care for each other in marriage, they create a spirit

unique unto themselves which binds them closer than any spoken or written words. Marriage is a promise, a potential made in the hearts of two people who love each other and takes a lifetime to fulfill.

“Blessing for a Marriage” by James Dillet Freeman

May your marriage bring you all the exquisite excitements a marriage should bring, and may life grant you also patience, tolerance, and understanding. May you always need one another – not so much to fill your emptiness as to help you to know your fullness. A mountain needs a valley to be complete; the valley does not make the mountain less, but more; and the valley is more a valley because it has a mountain towering over it. So let it be with you and you. May you need one another, but not out of weakness. May you want one another, but not out of lack. May you entice one another, but not compel one another. May you embrace one another, but not out encircle one another. May you succeed in all important ways with one another, and not fail in the little graces. May you look for things to praise, often say, “I love you!” and take no notice of small faults. If you have quarrels that push you apart, may both of you hope to have good sense enough to take the first step back. May you enter into the mystery which is the awareness of one another’s presence – no more physical than spiritual, warm and near when you are side by side, and warm and near when you are in separate rooms or even distant cities. May you have happiness, and may you find it making one another happy. May you have love, and may you find it loving one another.